

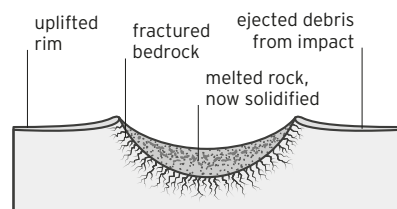
CORE Earth's innermost layer. It consists of a solid inner core and a liquid outer core, both made of nickel-iron.

CORIOLIS EFFECT The tendency for the direction of winds and currents to be deflected. Due to Earth's rotation, winds are deflected to the right in the Northern Hemisphere and left in the Southern Hemisphere. Without the Coriolis effect, air would simply flow directly from areas of high pressure to low pressure. See also *anticyclone*, *cyclone*.

CORROSION A form of chemical erosion in which water dissolves minerals in rocks and washes them away.

COUNTRY ROCK Existing rock into which an igneous intrusion invades. See also *igneous intrusion* (panel).

CRATER ▼ A bowl-shaped depression through which a volcano erupts gases, lava, ash, or volcanic bombs. Another form of crater is caused by a large meteorite impact.



CRATON See *shield*.

CRESCENTIC DUNE See *barchan*.

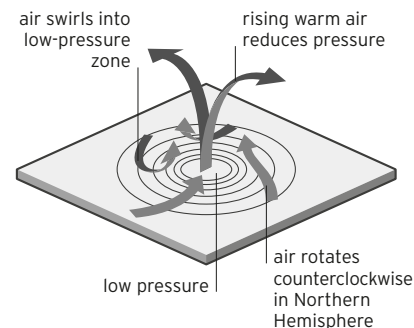
CREVASSE See panel (below).

CRUST Earth's rocky outermost layer. The continents and their margins are made of thicker but less dense continental crust, while thinner, denser oceanic crust underlies the floor of the deep oceans. See also *continental crust*, *oceanic crust*.

CRYOTURBATION The churning up of different layers of soil by repeated freezing and thawing. Also called frost-churning.

CRYSTAL Any solid in which the individual molecules are arranged in a regular geometrical pattern. Calcite and quartz, for example, form crystals.

CURRENT The flow of water in an ocean, lake, or river.



CYCLONE ▲ A weather system in which winds circulate around an area of low pressure. A tropical cyclone is

another name for a hurricane or typhoon. See also *anticyclone*, *depression*, *hurricane*, *pressure system*.

D

DECIDUOUS Describing trees and shrubs with leaves that die and fall at a particular time of year. See also *coniferous*, *evergreen*.

DEEP-SEA FAN A fan-shaped deposit of sediment on the ocean floor, usually at the bottom of the continental slope, deposited by turbidity currents. It is also known as an abyssal fan. See also *turbidity current*.

DEEP-SEA TRENCH A canyonlike depression in the ocean floor. Such trenches occur where one tectonic plate is pushing under another at a subduction zone. They are the deepest regions of the oceans. See also *boundary* (panel), *subduction*.

DEFORMATION The change in shape of rocks caused by the pressure of geological movements.

DELTA The area of gently sloping silt, sand, and other sediments built up by a river as it enters the ocean or a lake.

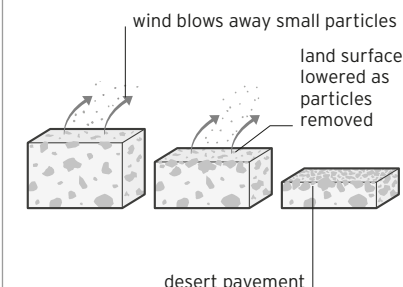
DENDRITIC DRAINAGE The pattern of streams and rivers in a drainage basin resembling the twigs and branches of a tree. See also *drainage basin*.

DEPOSITION The laying down of silt, sand, gravel, and other sediments by rivers, ocean currents, moving ice, or the wind.

DEPOSITIONAL COAST A coast where there is net deposition of sediments. This may result from longshore drift or the deposition of sediments in estuaries and deltas. See also *longshore drift*.

DEPRESSION A weather system where winds circulate around an area of low pressure. Also called a cyclone. See also *cyclone*, *pressure system*.

DESERT PAVEMENT ▼ A surface layer of closely packed rock fragments in a desert.



DESERT VARNISH A glossy orange, brown, or black coating sometimes found on the surface of desert rocks that have been exposed to the atmosphere for a long time.

DESERTIFICATION The conversion of a formerly fertile region into desert.

DESTRUCTIVE BOUNDARY See *convergent boundary*.

DEW POINT The temperature at which, under given conditions, liquid water in the atmosphere begins to condense. See *condensation*.

CREVASSE

A crevasse is a deep fissure in a glacier or other ice body. Crevasses usually form when some areas of ice move faster than others, consequently splitting the ice. This

happens when glaciers change direction or pass over uneven topography, such as a rock ridge. Crevasses are usually wider at the top than at the bottom.

